The arrival of Dissenting Protestant Missionaries, such as William Carey[20] and John Thomas, in Bengal in 1793, made matters worse, and by 1811 it was feared even by the House of Lords that the rising number of Protestant denominations in England would render the Church of England a denominational minority. This led to competitive evangelism, wherein each group tried to win more converts for itself (‘soul harvesting’) to prove its commitment to the gospel, with both groups agreeing on the need for greater missionary activity in Bharat.[21] This was captured in the proposal put forth to the British Parliament in 1811 by William Wilberforce,[22] a British politician and Protestant Christian, which required the Company to finance missionary activities in its territories.[23] This proposal was defeated by both the Anglican Church and the Company for their own reasons, the former fearing the growth of Dissenting Protestantism and the latter being concerned about missionary activity interfering with commerce by alienating the native population. The Company’s reluctance to institutionalise missionary activity was also partly owed to the experience of the Vellore Mutiny in 1806, which resulted in the death of 200 in a garrison of 370 due to a revolt of Indian soldiers against their officers.[24] The revolt was triggered by apprehensions among the soldiers that the Company was intent on converting them to Christianity by force. Therefore, the Company had its own reasons for partially staving off missionary activity at the levels sought by pro-mission groups.

However, between 1811 and 1813, the chorus for greater missionary activity in Bharat grew, and one of the reasons marshalled as the pretext for it was the inadequacy of the number of ministers of religion and chaplains in Bharat, which supposedly had led to ‘grossly immoral behaviour’ on the part of the Europeans. The blame for their immorality was, of course, conveniently laid at the doors of the native heathen population, which was deemed to be fundamentally and inherently immoral. Therefore, while the excuse cited was the growing European immorality in Bharat, the goal was ultimately the conversion of Indians, who had to be saved from their ignorance, darkness and devil-worshipping ways. To support their case of inherent immorality of the ‘Hindoos’, Hindu beliefs and practices were demonised, as evidenced by the propagandisation of the annual Shri Jagannath Rath Yatra at Puri (Odisha), as a ‘dangerous cult’ and the brazen exaggeration of the prevalence of Sati.[25] In this regard, the writings of